

Argument Lab

Fixing the Term

Part 1: Spot the Shift

For each argument below, identify the key term that changes meaning and briefly state the two different ideas it refers to.

1. “A feather is light. What is light cannot be dark. Therefore a feather cannot be dark.”
2. “The judge said the defendant had a fair trial. But the weather that day was not fair—it rained. Therefore the trial was not fair.”
3. “Only natural substances are healthy. This vitamin is made in a laboratory, so it is not natural. Therefore this vitamin is not healthy.”
4. “We must protect free speech. Therefore no one should be allowed to shout down a speaker on campus.”
5. *Macbeth*: “A real man acts boldly. Macbeth hesitates to kill Duncan. Therefore Macbeth is not a real man.”
6. *Julius Caesar*: “Brutus is honorable. Honorable men always act justly. Therefore Brutus’s killing of Caesar must be just.”

Part 2: Repair the Argument

Choose one argument from Part 1, preferably one of the Shakespeare examples if you know the text. Rewrite it so that the key term is used in only one clear sense. Then explain whether the repaired argument now supports its conclusion.

Part 3: Create

Write two short arguments on the same topic. You may use a public issue, a school issue, *Macbeth*, or *Julius Caesar*.

- In the first argument, use a key term in two different senses on purpose.
- In the second argument, use the same term consistently with a fixed meaning.

Exit Claim

Portfolio exit: In three or four sentences, explain how the habit of fixing terms connects to the four-step analysis you learned in Week 1. Name one word from *Macbeth* or *Julius Caesar* that would need careful definition before an argument about the play could be judged.